

EFC

March 15, 2026

“He Didn’t Need to Do That!”

Matthew 3:13-17

Good morning, English Fellowship Church. My name is Jeremy, and I’m one of the Pastors here. This morning we continue our series in the book of Matthew. Remember, Matthew’s goal is to help us know Jesus, teach us what it means to be His people, and send us on Jesus’ mission to spread the Gospel to the world. So far, Matthew has revealed to us that Jesus is the rightful King of the Jews, the prophesied Messiah who is not only human but also divine. The past two weeks we have focused on John the Baptist, whom God sent ahead of Jesus to call the people to repent of their sins, so that they would be ready to receive Jesus. This morning, Jesus Himself comes on the scene to be baptized by John.

Pray.

In the fall, my family went through a difficult stretch. Between sickness, lots of responsibilities, hosting visitors, health problems with our cats, and moving houses (after 13 years in the same house), we were pretty worn down. Some friends of ours heard about what was going on, and cooked dinner for us – not once, not twice, but three times! Not only was it delicious food, but their generosity and love was profound. It was far more than might be expected (indeed, they weren’t required to do anything!). We were deeply touched; looking back, I say, “Wow! They didn’t need to do that!” Perhaps you have experienced such love from someone in your life.

At the heart of today’s story, Jesus does something to which we could easily say, “He didn’t need to do that!” And, honestly, we might wonder why He did. If you’ll remember from last week, John the Baptist was baptizing people “for repentance” (Matthew 3:11) as they came “confessing their sins” (Matthew 3:6). So why would Jesus come to be baptized by John? Jesus didn’t need to repent of anything; indeed, He is the only human being who ever lived a perfect, sinless life. So why would Jesus insist on being baptized by John? Let’s read the scene from Matthew 3:13-17.

Matthew 3:13-17 Then Jesus came from Galilee to the Jordan to John, to be baptized by him. John would have prevented him, saying, "I need to be baptized by you, and do you come to me?" But Jesus answered him, "Let it be so now, for thus it is fitting for us to fulfill all righteousness." Then he consented. And when Jesus was baptized, immediately he went up from the water, and behold, the heavens were opened to him, and he saw the Spirit of God descending like a dove and coming to rest on him; and

behold, a voice from heaven said, "This is my beloved Son, with whom I am well pleased."

Considering that Jesus was sinless and didn't need to repent of anything, we might think "He didn't need to do that." But we would be only partly correct. Because, though He didn't need to be baptized for repentance, He did need to be baptized because it was the Father's will for Him, and Jesus came to do the Father's will.

This points us to the first reason Jesus was baptized: Jesus was baptized by John because of His dedication to the Father's will.

- "Let it be so now; for thus it is fitting for us to fulfill all righteousness."
 - o Fulfill already used many times in Matthew, and will be used throughout the book to consistently mean "completion of God's will".
- Jesus is completely dedicated to obeying His Father and fulfilling every aspect of the Father's will for Him.
- And what was God's will for Jesus? That He save us from our sins so we could be restored in our relationship with God.

Second reason why Jesus was baptized: for His identification

- a. Identification of who Jesus is
 - i. Jesus is the Servant, prophesied in Isaiah
 - 1. Hinted at in Jesus' statement
 - a. Matthew 3:15 "Let it be so now, for thus it is fitting for us to fulfill all righteousness."
 - b. Isaiah 53:11 "by his knowledge shall the righteous one, my servant, make many to be accounted righteous"
 - 2. Confirmed in what follows the baptism
 - a. Matthew 3:16-17 And when Jesus was baptized, immediately he went up from the water, and behold, the heavens were opened to him, and he saw the Spirit of God descending like a dove and coming to rest on him; and behold, a voice from heaven said, "This is my beloved Son, with whom I am well pleased."
 - b. Isaiah 42:1 Behold my servant, whom I uphold, my chosen, in whom my soul delights; I have put my Spirit upon him....
 - i. Spirit upon Him
 - ii. Soul delights
 - c. Confirmed in full in Matthew 12:15-21
 - 3. Important that we note two things about the Servant prophecies of Isaiah:
 - a. Obedient, when Israel (and humanity) wasn't

- b. His obedience (dedication) would require great suffering
 - i. Dove – sacrificial system
 - ii. Isaiah 52-53
 - 4. And Jesus knows it, and embraces God's plan for Him and His role in it, though it is a painful road to walk. He is no victim; from the start, Jesus knows who He is, and knows what His dedication to the Father will cost Him, and He embraces it anyway.
 - ii. Jesus is the Suffering Servant who is the Son of God in whom the Father delights
 - b. Jesus identifies with the sinners He came to save, which was how He would fulfill God's plan of redemption and accomplish our salvation.
 - i. Jesus Himself didn't need to be baptized for His own sins; but in order to save us, He had to identify with us in every respect except for our sin.
 - 1. Identifying with my children
 - ii. So, the High King of Heaven, to whom all of creation owes its existence and before whom every person will one day bow the knee, walks into the dirty Jordan river to obey His Father, and to join Himself to us.
2. Justification – because of Jesus' identification with us, all who are saved by grace through faith in Christ – all who are united with Him –
- a. are justified,
 - i. Legal term – declared innocent, in right standing
 - 1. "Just as if I'd" never sinned
 - ii. Romans 4:3-5 For what does the Scripture say? "Abraham believed God, and it was counted to him as righteousness." Now to the one who works, his wages are not counted as a gift but as his due. And to the one who does not work but trusts him who justifies the ungodly, his faith is counted as righteousness....
 - iii. For all who trust in Jesus, the Son of God who died on the cross for their sins, a great exchange takes place: Jesus takes our sin and is counted as guilty, while He gives us His righteousness and we are counted as innocent.
 - 1. 2 Corinthians 5:21 For our sake he made him to be sin who knew no sin, so that in him we might become the righteousness of God.
 - 2. 2 Corinthians 8:9 For you know the grace of our Lord Jesus Christ, that though he was rich, yet for your sake he became poor, so that you by his poverty might become rich. and receive from Him a new identity:
 - b. All who trust in Jesus receive a new identity as a result
 - i. We become sons and daughters of God
 - 1. Romans 8:15-17 For you did not receive the spirit of slavery to fall back into fear, but you have received the Spirit of adoption as sons, by whom we cry, "Abba! Father!" The

Spirit himself bears witness with our spirit that we are children of God, and if children, then heirs - heirs of God and fellow heirs with Christ, provided we suffer with him in order that we may also be glorified with him.

- ii. And what is that new identity? In Christ, we become the beloved, in whom God delights.
 - 1. Romans 1:7 To all those in Rome who are loved by God and called to be saints: Grace to you and peace from God our Father and the Lord Jesus Christ.
- iii. Sons and daughters, beloved by God, who delights in us not because of what we've done, nor who we are, but specifically because of who Jesus is and what He has done, which is credited to us by grace as we receive Him by faith

So, taking this all together, we see that: Jesus was dedicated to perfectly fulfilling God's will for Him, including all the suffering our redemption and rescue from our sin would require; He identified with us fully, in order that all who trust in Him might be justified before God, saved from our sins, adopted as beloved sons and daughters of God, and (as we'll see as Matthew continues) transformed to live the abundant kingdom life.

It's not only that He didn't need to do that (repent); He didn't need to do that (identify with us on His mission to the cross), for us!

Sets the stage for understanding and responding to Jesus' public ministry, which is about to start and which is in focus as we move forward in Matthew: we need to remember throughout who Jesus is (the Obedient, Suffering Servant), and who we are (adopted sons and daughters, beloved in Christ, who obey all He commands not because we are earning, but because we are becoming who we already are in Christ).